

TAPS Supplemental Final Essay

"I'm Here For You"

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"I'm Here for You" was born from a group discussion surrounding adaptations of public domain materials. Each member of my group, Jurain, George, Caitlin, Olivia, and Claire, brought in multiple sources that they felt held weight as short play adaptations. Being one of the last to share my ideas in our counter-clockwise order, I had heard my teammates pitch *Les Misérables*, the Coin of Domitianus artifact, the Triangle Shirtwaist Factory fire, "The Ballad of Little Sadie," and the Legend of the White Snake. I had brought in a story concerning the origins of the word "robot", and "Lazy", a jazz song from Irving Berlin. Caitlin was the last to share, and as she was talking, unsure if it was something she explicitly said or something I inferred, I became attached to the idea that we wanted to tell a story that specifically highlights the "inescapability of circumstance".

While, overall, our ideas overlapped in broader themes of love, passion, or death, I had a feeling we wanted to tell a tragic story. But, showing tragic stories is difficult and heavy. I also don't tend to think situations are inherently tragic, so if we wanted tragedy, I hoped it would come from the audience simultaneously relating to and despising the journey unfolding on stage. I wanted to show that people who were alive, passionate, and surrounded by love could still experience tragedy while continuing to exist in their loving, breathing bodies.

Honing in on a theme that seemed to creep under all of our ideas, I displayed support for Olivia's source: Plato's Allegory of the Cave. My initial reaction was that the allegory of the cave would be an especially interesting story to talk about friendship. I've always had an aversion to writing about romantic relationships, simply because I believe stories about found community or inherent friendship are too often watered down by romantic subplots. Olivia's specific contribution to this idea was focusing on the community inside the cave - revealing that the relationships within the cave were important, but overlooked as a result of knowledge of the outer world. In fact, Olivia's suggestion of *Les Mis* was directly accompanied by the idea that we ought to explore Eponine and Cosette's relationship, rather than their relationships with their male counterparts.

In Plato's allegory, one of the cave dwellers sees a new form, for the first time, after having spent his whole life thinking the world was contained within the ranges of movement of shadows on a cave wall. Those shadows were tangible, and said real things about the cave dweller's lived experience. But, when the new form of life is encountered, Plato stresses that this is the form of the good, closer to truth than whatever reality existed in the cave. In fact, the traveler of the cave attempts to educate the cave-dwellers and is met with pushback and hostility. While I am very fond of the scientific, and idealistic message written by Plato, it's hard not to see the parallels between the cave traveler and a missionary, or a liberal/conservative child screaming relentlessly at their right wing/left wing parents to become better people, or 'expose them to the truth'—a tactic that, combined with meditation, prayers, or dance, can easily be misconstrued as cultish behavior. It is the practicalities and difficulties of communication between the cave traveler and the cave dwellers that swayed me towards this story.

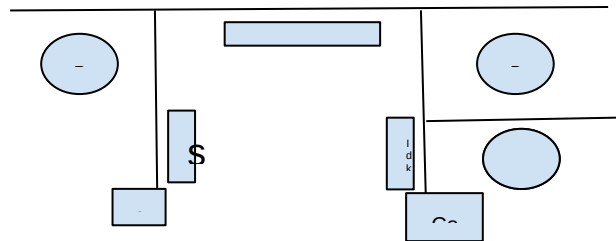
I began thinking about stories in which we could show just how much communication was in some way complicated or even destroyed by the possession or lack of a body. We have to

deal with our bodies every day, our thoughts are corporeal, even if mind is separated from body, our mind tends to express through the body, the body being its only outlet/interface with an external (practical) world. Given the seedlings of “capitalism”, “industrialization”, “technology”, “faith”, “and friendship, and my inclination towards stories that expose digital interventions of the natural experience, we decided that we would tell the allegory of the cave by focusing on the impacts of the cave traveler’s shared knowledge on the cave dwellers. Is the push-back of the cave dwellers justified in some world? What information is good for us? Is the pursuit of knowledge rid of generational and emotional fatality? We left with a core idea, that upon reflection, may be synthesized as “the journey through an echo chamber” or “acquiring knowledge that is inaccessible to others”.

Given that our echo chamber was digital, we immediately turned to thinking about staging and characters. If we were to have characters in the digital world, how would we display that on stage? Would they be disembodied voices? would they show up as “text” as many digital voices appear in our lives? Quickly, we felt it important to embody the voices. We then thought about the anonymity of these voices. Would they have names? What are we allowed to know about them? We didn’t really decide this until the script was written, but it felt like some sort of anonymity was important to us, given that our initial staging ideas had the voices seated during their scenes, back turned to the audience, laptop glow visible to the audience.

To the right is an initial graphic I made.

This diagram is indicative of a few other things, our setting and our family. In this diagram you see an apartment blueprint with three roommates, two computer stations, and a studio living room kitchen. By showcasing our protagonist, Lily, engaging in online interaction while simultaneously forcing her to exist within a physical apartment space, we let the audience experience distinct dramatic irony. The audience knows her downward spiral is happening regardless of physical reality. We “took away” what makes online conversations feel natural. Even when the intense online conversations are happening, the roommates are seen living their lives normally in the background, physically distancing the digital obsession from the tangible warmth of the apartment



I wrote the first draft of the script to provide a rough baseline for us to work with, largely because I was feeling antsy about the timeline and wanted my group to meet on Thursday with something concrete to work on in class time. For blocking, we mostly followed our inner impulses, doing what felt natural in the moment while relying on the overall structure within the stage directions. There were a few movements that I thought ought to be hit. I wasn’t rigidly committed to my initial script, but I did push back on certain edits. For instance, the group suggested cutting the line where Lily calls Diana an ‘attention whore’ to make the monologue strictly about the two friends teaming up on her. For one, I thought vulgar language and the willingness to use it in front of someone’s face was necessary - something that the internet and especially reddit desensitizes us to. Additionally, the name-calling would give Diana (played by Jurain) something concrete to hold a grudge against in the following scenes. Furthermore, I really wanted Lily to do something objectively hurtful. A friend might understand feeling a little

left out or accept that unconsciously you can make a friend feel that way, but name calling is not one of them. What seems really easy to respond to and type out on a keyboard is so different from communicating out loud. There were other similar moments I won't detail here, but I strongly felt these beats of escalation were important to disrupt the otherwise naturalistic, 'slice of life' dialogue.

We took a very collaborative approach to directing. Being on the same page after multiple script edits made the process feel pretty frictionless. One person would remind us of an overall idea we had that could turn into a specific stage direction, others contributed props or brought their own and decided to use those props independently which we all trusted. Since a roommate's situation isn't all too foreign to us, this wasn't hard. I think directing was also a group effort demonstrated by us asking each other as a group how certain lines were read/checking that lines were being received in the way they were intended. Overall, directing did feel a bit more like an afterthought and given more time and a directing position that is separate from acting could have contributed more greatly to our final performance.

As *Voices*, we wanted to contrast our movements with the roommates but at the same time, had very friendly human voices. We wanted to portray a friend's voice. How much language can seem neutral or positive when there's nothing to back it, no truth behind its support, no intention to support, just direction to. In contrast, George and Jurain don't necessarily profess overt emotional support to Lily's face, but we see it in their actions (like planning the surprise party). They act neutrally enough that Claire's reactions could believably swing their behavior toward the positive or negative. I felt like Jurain and Claire's scene before the party was a really awesome demonstration of what the acting was supposed to convey in the show: a desperate plea to hear you out confronted with an anger that is completely fueled and built up by a digital experience. I thought Jurain beautifully conveyed the emotional toll of this speech through her character's sadness and disappointment toward Lily. I like to describe her reaction there as a 'what was this all for' moment.

Overall, the staging and prop use surpassed my expectations. I think we tried our hardest to bring a holistic and fully created version of our play to our final performance. However, there were areas where the production quality fell short in my estimation. We dealt with a few missed lines, and in hindsight, I wish the *Voices* had known their lines more solidly so we could have rehearsed more fluidly with the light cues up and down. This process also taught me a lot about the friction between written dialogue and embodied performance. Sometimes, the words on the page are just not evocative enough on their own. For example, during the climax, Claire (playing Lily) made her character's internal state much more specific by explicitly stating, "I felt validated". Initially, I didn't think spelling that out was necessary; I felt that the specific emotion could have been conveyed differently—through the acting and the weight of the moment, rather than being explicitly spoken. This definitely made me reflect on the idea that truly good text should feel universal to an actor. No matter who is playing the role, the underlying feeling ought to be inherently supported by the subtext and the situation. While an actor brings crucial embodiment to a role, the communication between actors is greatly facilitated by text itself, or the preceding context. In a short play like this, the text ought to have done the heavy lifting so that our actors don't feel the need to overtly state their character's psychological state. As a result, too much subtlety made the explication of certain moments in the editing phase, necessary.

The script had great potential to change, but I am truly proud of the work we put up. As someone who typically writes quickly with improvisation and comedy in mind, this class was a

new undertaking for myself and I think “I’m Here for you” is one of the most intentional pieces of writing and performance I have ever put up collaboratively. I am certain I will engage in future collaborative playwriting and musical writing with the tools provided to me through this class. Thank you team “I’m Here for You”. And, thank you Scott!